February 1975

It had been six months since my parents had had a good night's sleep—six long and weary months, with the nights as laborious as the days spent changing diapers and tending to the needs of two little ones about the house. Little Anshuman missed his grandmother, who had gone back to Badaun, Uttar Pradesh, in the first week of January, since Guwahati's humid winters had become unbearable for her aching joints. Papaji and Maa missed her too. She had been a helping hand in taking care of Dada while I continued to raise hell with my periodic cries and untimely demands to be fed. But one fine night in February, I slept throughout, bringing some much-needed respite to Papaji and Maa.

'Are these dark circles under my eyes?' asked Maa. For the first time in a while she had found some time to herself. And Papaji could finally rip open the old radio whose dial had started to jam. It was half-past-six in the morning.

'Signs of insomnia,' Papaji said as he unscrewed the components of the radio.

'How strange,' Maa added, 'we have time now, but no sleep. Anshuman at least wore away the nights peacefully.'

'Don't blame my little Gunju,' my father said, still busy with the screwdriver. 'She'll make us proud one day, you'll see.'

'Of course she will,' my mother said, smiling. Papaji adjusted the dial, and after some indiscreet noise, the radio played the song *Karvatein Badalte Rahe Saari Raat Hum* (I kept twisting and turning all night long). As if on cue, Dada pulled my pram into the room with his little hands. I had begun to cry louder than the radio. Maa at once got out of bed and held me. Papaji ruffled Dada's hair and appreciated him for being responsible. Dada turned around and, still sleepy, crashed on their bed.

It had been a full hour since I had been crying in Maa's lap. All that rocking and feeding had been in vain. Papaji's efforts to divert my attention lasted for a few minutes before he became restless. The only unaffected person was Dada, who still slept as if on anaesthesia.